line and it dipped in over his head.

I actually got the first blow on my left foot at the Riazor stadium. There were about five minutes left and I had the ball over by the touchline. As I cleared it, Diego Tristan, their center-forward, came in with his foot high and caught my standing leg. Every player knows how dangerous that kind of challenge is and the pain I got straight after it made me think he might have broken my ankle. As it was, there was just a cut and some bad bruising. Even so, I was on crutches and couldn't put any weight on my foot on the journey home. I remember there were one or two pictures and headlines wondering if I'd be fit for the World Cup, never mind the second leg at Old Trafford. I had scans as a precaution, but everything was fine ahead of the game a week later. At least, that's what I thought.

I was really looking forward to the return game: it's always exciting against Deportivo. The first quarter of an hour, they really had a go at us. We ended up winning 3–2 and going through to the semis. By the time that had happened, though, I was in a hospital bed. Just as we were starting to get a grip on the game, twenty minutes in, I went in for what looked like a 60/40 challenge in my favor fifteen yards outside their penalty area. I think the other bloke, Aldo Duscher, decided to even up the odds: another Argentinian midfield player leaving his mark on my life. All I was thinking about was winning the challenge: you never worry about getting an injury at the same time. I made it to the ball just before him but Duscher slid in, two-footed and studs up, and caught my left foot instead.

I remember lying there, dumped on the floor, and holding my foot which was killing me. I tried to get myself up but, as well as hurting, the foot had gone floppy. I couldn't stand on it. They carried me over to the touchline. I was still thinking I'd run it off.

'Just spray something on it. Put some water on it. It'll be fine.'

They did that but then, when I went to stand, I almost fell over. I just couldn't put any weight on the foot at all. The pain wouldn't let my boot even touch the ground. The United doctor was bending over me. He took the boot off and felt around where I told him it was hurting. It was like something giving way inside: what should have been firm felt flimsy. I could actually feel the bone moving. I said it before the Doc did:

'It's broken.'

'Yes. I think it is.'